They were outfitted with metal gates and security cameras; armed guards lingered outside, and accompanied the settlers whenever they left.

Elad, and a second group called Ateret Cohanim (“Crown of the Priests”), have spent years trying to “Judaize” Silwan. Sometimes they go to court to have Palestinians evicted from their homes, on the basis of Ottoman-era land deeds (Silwan once had a sizable Jewish population, and is home to an important Jewish religious site). In 2014 they tried a new tactic, approaching homeowners through straw buyers and offering exorbitant sums for their properties. “A broker came to me two months ago, a Palestinian guy, and he offered to pay me full price for my house,” said Mahmoud Abdel Qader, who lives near the base of the hill. “One million shekels! He said we could go to the municipality immediately and do the paperwork.”

One million shekels, roughly $250,000, is a steep price for an aging flat adjacent to a makeshift garbage dump. But several other Silwan residents had similar experiences, as did a man from Jabal al-Mukaber, a similarly grim neighborhood further south. In each case, they said, the brokers were Palestinians claiming to be affiliated with the Islamic Movement, a religious and social organization.

Naftali Bennett, then the economy minister, explained the effort in a cheerful video released after the settlers moved in. “About twenty-five years ago, a wonderful organization decided to return the City of David to Jewish hands,” he said. “Slowly, and with patience, it started purchasing homes at full price, and populated them with Jewish families.” Bennett went on to explain that the previous week’s purchases “doubled” the Jewish population in the area. “[Now] there is a Jewish majority,” he claimed. In fact there is no such thing in Silwan, even in the small area designated as the “City of David,” where Jews now make up perhaps 20 per cent of the population. But the latest wave of settlement was another obstacle to a future division of Jerusalem.

There is a view, prevalent on the far right, that Netanyahu is a sort of crypto-leftist, secretly plotting to divide the city. The settlers in Silwan view themselves as a sort of beachhead, making it impossible to sever the neighborhood. “The objective, yes, it’s to strengthen the Jewish presence in all areas of East Jerusalem,” said Aryeh King, a member of the Jerusalem city council and right-wing activist who founded an organization devoted to settling Jews in East Jerusalem. “This way we can stop, or at least delay,